

Peace, Politics, and Power, Under Exam Conditions

Lesson 37 — Essay practice: the post-Gulf War Middle East

What you will know and be able to do

1

Write a complete, timed essay drawing on everything from Lessons 33–36

2

Apply command-term discipline, structure, historiography, and evaluation together

3

Self-assess against the criteria built since Lesson 1

4

Close Block B6 ready to examine the Arab Spring and the region's most recent transformations

Four different responses to the same underlying vacuum

Four lessons have traced strikingly different responses to the post-Gulf War moment: a genuine but limited peace process, a resurgent political Islam filling secular nationalism's gaps, a war launched on since-discredited grounds, and a terrorist network reshaped by that very war's chaos. Today tests whether you can hold this entire, varied arc together.

What connects Oslo, Hamas, Iraq, and Al-Qaeda

Each of these four episodes responds, in a different way, to the same underlying question: what fills the space when an older political order — secular nationalism, Cold War-era alliances, or Saddam's regime itself — loses its legitimacy or its grip. Peace processes, religious movements, foreign invasion, and terrorist networks were four competing answers operating simultaneously across the same region.

A full argument-evaluation essay

“The failure of secular nationalist and diplomatic solutions, more than any single external actor's decisions, best explains the Middle East's trajectory between 1991 and 2003.” To what extent do you agree?

A representative Paper 3 style question drawing on Lessons 33–36.

PRACTICE • 40 MIN

Write your complete essay now

Write a full essay in response to today's question, under real time pressure, without looking back at earlier lesson slides until you finish.

- Plan your position and structure before writing a single sentence
- Use specific evidence from at least three of Lessons 33–36
- Integrate at least one genuine historiographical reference
- Reach a real, specific judgement in your conclusion

Checking your own essay

Did you weigh internal regional factors — Oslo's structural limits, the Brotherhood's decades of groundwork — against external actors' decisions, like the 2003 invasion itself? Did you avoid treating this period as a single, simple story rather than several overlapping, sometimes contradictory developments? Did your conclusion reach a genuine, specific judgement?

What a strong final judgement sounds like

“Secular nationalism's failures created the conditions both political Islam and continued conflict could exploit — Oslo's structural limits and the PLO's declining legitimacy directly enabled Hamas's rise. Yet external decisions, especially the 2003 invasion, then reshaped that landscape further still, in ways internal regional dynamics alone would not have produced. Both forces mattered; neither alone is sufficient.”

Precision, not just presence

This block offered several real historiographical references: Anziska on Oslo's structural limits, the competing Camp David narratives, Sageman's scepticism about Al-Qaeda's coherence, and ongoing historians' debates over the 2003 invasion's true motive. A strong essay selects the one or two most directly relevant to its specific argument, rather than listing all of them regardless of fit.

What Block B7 covers next

Everything in this block set the stage for 2011's most dramatic regional upheaval yet: the Arab Spring. Block B7 covers how popular uprisings, some successful and some catastrophic, reshaped the region one final time within our period of study.

Block B6 recap

Declaration of Principles

Oslo's 1993 founding document, deferring the hardest questions to later.

Bush Doctrine

The pre-emption principle underlying the 2003 Iraq War's justification.

Social institution building

The Muslim Brotherhood's decades-long groundwork enabling Hamas's rise.

Franchising

Al-Qaeda's post-2001 shift toward semi-autonomous regional affiliates.

How much of this period was genuinely unpredictable?

Consider, before moving on: could an observer in 1991, at the Gulf War's end, have reasonably predicted Oslo's collapse, Hamas's rise to genuine political power, a second Iraq war, or Al-Qaeda's transformation into a global network? Some elements were arguably foreseeable given existing tensions; others depended heavily on specific, contingent decisions no one could have reliably anticipated.

Contingency versus structural explanation

The strongest Paper 3 essays distinguish between outcomes that were structurally likely, given underlying conditions, and outcomes that depended on specific individual choices or chance events. This block offers rich material for practising exactly that distinction — carry the habit forward into every essay from here on.

Sorting this block's four episodes

MORE STRUCTURALLY LIKELY

- Some form of Palestinian political mobilisation, given decades of occupation
- Continued great-power interest in a strategically vital, oil-rich region
- Ongoing tension between secular and religious political visions

MORE CONTINGENT ON SPECIFIC CHOICES

- The specific collapse of Camp David negotiations in July 2000
- The particular decision to invade Iraq in 2003 rather than pursue other options
- Bin Laden's own personal reaction to US troops in Saudi Arabia specifically

Structural and contingent factors interact, not compete

This sorting exercise is a tool for thinking, not a rigid rule — structural conditions make certain contingent choices more likely, or more consequential, without making any single choice inevitable. The strongest essays use this distinction to sharpen an argument, not to reduce complex causation into two artificially separate boxes.

Camp David 2000, reconsidered

Return to the pro-Israeli and pro-Palestinian accounts from Lesson 33. Notice that both sides agree on the same basic facts — the offer, the gap on refugees and Jerusalem, the summit's failure — while disagreeing sharply on how to weigh Arafat's rejection against the offer's genuine limits. This is historiography at its clearest: identical evidence, different judgement.

What to avoid in your own essays

Treating Hamas and Hezbollah as interchangeable, despite their genuinely different origins. Assuming the 2003 invasion's stated justification was necessarily its real motive, or dismissing it out of hand either way without evidence. Describing Al-Qaeda as a single, tightly organised actor without acknowledging real scholarly doubt about that framing. Each of these habits weakens an otherwise strong argument.

Which single lesson from this block would you choose?

If a real Paper 3 question forced you to draw on only one episode from Lessons 33–36 to support an argument about foreign intervention's effects on the region, which would you pick, and why? Being able to justify that choice quickly is exactly the kind of decisive, evidence-based thinking this paper rewards.

What we now understand about this era

From a genuine but structurally limited peace process, through political Islam's patient rise, to a war launched on collapsed justifications and the terrorist network that war's own chaos empowered — four overlapping stories about what fills a vacuum when older political orders lose their grip, none of them adequately explained by a single cause alone.

Lesson 38 — The Arab Spring begins

Next lesson starts Block B7, our final Middle East block: the self-immolation that sparked uprisings across an entire region, and why some succeeded while others collapsed into civil war.